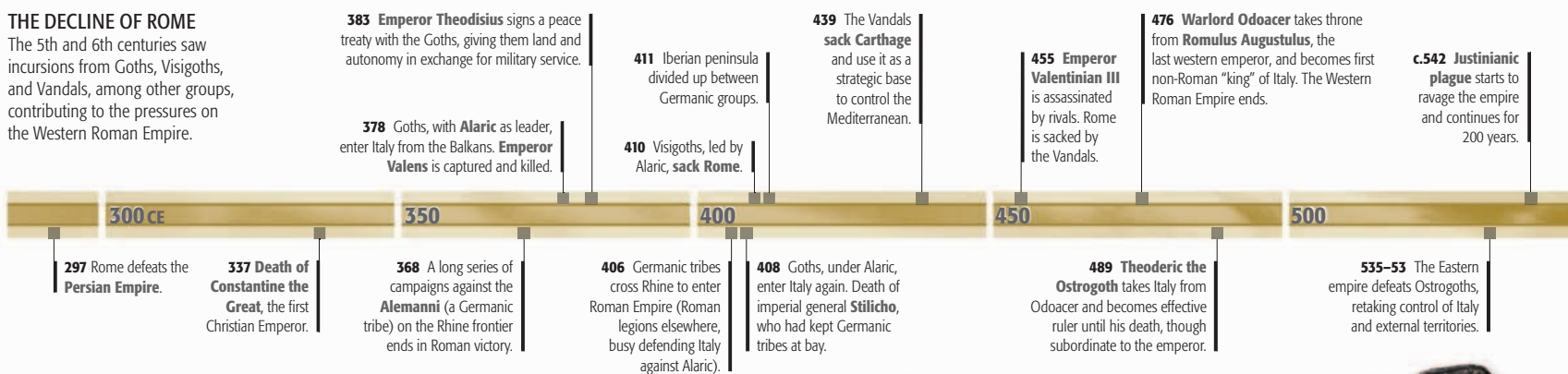


THE DECLINE OF ROME

The 5th and 6th centuries saw incursions from Goths, Visigoths, and Vandals, among other groups, contributing to the pressures on the Western Roman Empire.



This figure on horseback has been identified as Hostilian, who was a Roman general and a short-lived emperor before his death from the plague in 251 CE.

All the Romans in the relief are shown in armor, with clean-shaven faces wearing expressions of calm superiority.

This fine carving includes an incredibly detailed rendering of *lorica hamata*—a kind of metal-link armor worn by certain Roman soldiers.



Romans battling barbarians

The famous Ludovisi Battle Sarcophagus, an imperial Roman marble sarcophagus, depicts Romans battling against Ostrogoth barbarians during the 3rd century CE. It has been dated to around 250–60 CE.

Writhing figures struggling closely together convey the chaos and drama of hand-to-hand battle.

for many years; Romans and Germanic people united to defeat Attila the Hun (see left) at the Battle of Châlons (France) in 451; the Visigoths had been Roman allies while also having a Gallic kingdom, but were then pushed south into Spain by Franks.

On some occasions the Romans tolerated, or were forced to accept, the settlement of barbarian groups on their lands. By 382 CE the Goths had assumed partial autonomy from the Romans and by 418 CE they were granted lands in Gaul (France). Where barbarians took over former Roman territories, they sometimes sought to supplant the old Roman aristocracy (as with the Vandals in North Africa), but in other places coexisted peacefully with them. There was much cultural cross-fertilization between the Romans and barbarians.

Weakening grip?

Another factor in the gradual fading of Roman power was the spread of plague and disease from the east. This led to severe shortages in the army and fewer people in general to support society. Various bouts of plague had spread through the empire in the 3rd century. Then the Justinianic plague broke out. Named after eastern Emperor Justinian, who retook the western empire in the mid-sixth century, it began in 542 CE and raged for 200 years. The effect on the population of the eastern Empire was devastating.

Other factors include a general decline in population, inflation, civil war, self-serving Roman corruption, and imperial overcultivation leading to loss of good agricultural land. These have variously been seen as reducing prosperity and resources, hastening the fading of the great urban centers of "classical" civilization and learning.

RELIGIOUS CHANGE

The rise of Christianity also played a major role in the new order. The "Arian" Christianity held by most

Frankish ax

Lightweight throwing axes were popular weapons of the Franks in the 5th century CE.



Germanic peoples was at odds with the more orthodox Christianity traditionally held by Roman peoples. Furthermore, the increasing power of the Christian church may have eroded some imperial authority (see AFTER).

AFTER

The Roman Empire lived on in the east for 1,000 years as the Byzantine Empire, while new forces shaped the Western world.

BYZANTINE EMPIRE

After damaging wars with the Persians, the Byzantine or East Roman Empire **198–99 >>** was too weak to face the challenges posed by Arab Muslim armies.

ARAB ADVANCE

Arab power, **united under the banner of Islam**, grew in the 7th and early 8th centuries with the capture of the Byzantine Levant, much of North Africa and Egypt, and attempts to take Constantinople **174–77 >>**.

LATIN CHRISTENDOM

The pope shifted his loyalty from Constantinople's Roman emperor to Frankish king Charlemagne (747–814), **194–95 >>**, crowning him Emperor of the Romans.

LATE ANTIQUITY

Distinctive communities that combined Germanic traditions, Latin Christianity, and aspects of Roman culture began to emerge in the post-Roman west, such as in Anglo-Saxon England.



ANGLO-SAXON
BELT BUCKLE